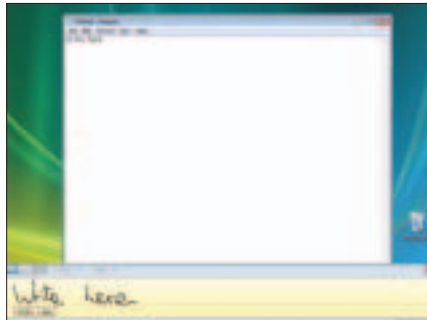


Hidden talents

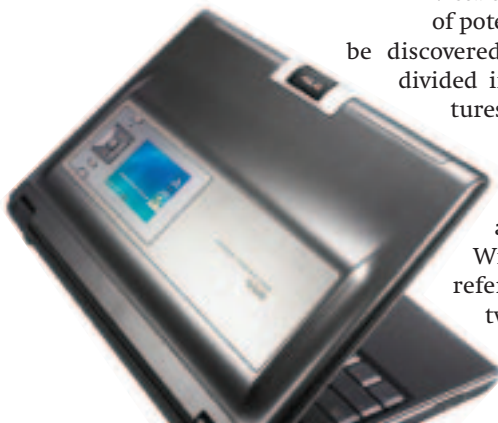
Windows Vista comes with several gigabytes' worth of hidden applications and utilities lurking beneath its surface. But are any of them worth uncovering? We investigate

Windows Vista is a large and multi-faceted operating system, and it is virtually unavoidable that some of its key elements will hog the lime-light, while others are pushed into the shadows. But just because Microsoft isn't making a big deal about them, it doesn't necessarily follow that Vista's less well-



Vista can convert handwriting in printed text, no matter how illegible your writing may be

The secondary display of compatible notebooks, and the screen of smartphones and PDAs, can be used to show Sideshow gadgets, such as the contents of your inbox



known aspects aren't worth talking about or bothering to explore.

In fact, as we saw earlier, Vista comes with a huge number of potential gems just waiting to be discovered. These can be roughly divided into two categories — features and functions. It's a subtle difference, but the former essentially refers to applications, tools and utilities included with Windows, while the latter refers to hidden settings, tweaks and alterations you can apply to your PC to customise or optimise it. We'll be dealing with

the second category later, but before that we'll put some of Vista's unsung features under the spotlight, and in the workshops that follow on from this article, demonstrate how to take full advantage of them. So, what are Vista's hidden features, why are they 'hidden', what purpose do they serve and are they any good?



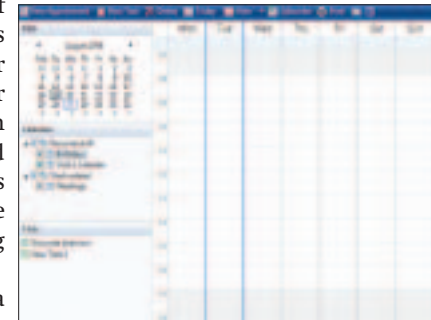
Pen flicks can be used to access frequently used commands by moving your stylus in a variety of ways

Vista's multi-tiered strategy

There is no denying Vista is Microsoft's most complete and feature-packed version of Windows to date. Things have come a long way over the years, but no matter how long you've been using Windows — and Vista, in particular — it's almost certain that there will still be something new to learn.

To some, this is a bonus, with all the hidden extras available only serving to prove that you're getting your money's worth when you buy a copy of Windows. On the other hand, Microsoft is often criticised for confusing users by cramming far too much in and for forcing consumers to carry the cost of all the 'bloatware' or unnecessary software included in Vista. After all, you're effectively paying for features that gobble up valuable system resources — features you might not even use.

There's certainly an argument to be had over whether a one-size-fits-all policy is really the best way to approach something like an operating system. Surely it would be better to create a simple



Windows Calendar makes it easy to avoid missing appointments; you can also eye other peoples' schedules